> the issues that lead to hesitation and doubts . . . we must try to settle the boundary question quickly . . . But, a shadow of uncertainty always hangs over the sensitive areas of the border region . . . It is because neither side knows where the Line of Actual Control is in these areas . . . That is why I have proposed resuming the process of clarifying it. We can do this without prejudice to our position on the boundary question.[103]

China remained unmoved. All that the joint statement could say was: 'The two sides affirmed that an early settlement of the boundary question serves the basic interests of the two countries and should be pursued as a strategic objective by the two governments.'[104] Despite Modi's very public pitch, Beijing refused to commit to a delineation of the LAC. Two years later, the two militaries squared off at Doklam, near the trijunction of India, Bhutan, and China. With the Doklam crisis, Rajiv Gandhi's 1988 policy of normalization leading to a border settlement had crumbled. It was being replaced by the view that a border settlement or at least a delineation of the LAC was a precondition for normalization – the position that Delhi had adopted after the 1962 war and abandoned in 1988.

To recap, in the period from 1981 to 2019 the two countries had forty-five rounds of border negotiations, which is an average of more than one round of talks a year over nearly forty years. The negotiations made it possible for India to abandon the corner in which it found itself after 1962, namely, that relations with China could not be normalized until a boundary settlement was reached. Also, there was much greater clarity on the concerns and preferences of the two sides. The old swap/barter deal was finally abandoned. It was replaced by the idea of a package settlement – settling the border sector by sector, with concessions to be made in all three sectors. The progress on clarifying each other's positions and agreeing to a broad set of protocols notwithstanding, negotiations achieved little after 2005. Indian frustration grew and Chinese obstinacy increased, climaxing in a series of military confrontations between 2013 and 2017. The confrontations caused Indian policy to shift back towards the older stand which tied normalization to a border settlement. The 2020 crisis in Ladakh threatened war. Between 1949 and 1961, India–China relations went from cooperation to conflict and war. The period from 1963 to 2020 was marked